

Atlantic Gazette

VOL. 1, NO. 096

2026-03-30

FEATURES

SystemD Contributor Harassed Over Optional Age Verification Field, Suggests Installer-Level Disabling

Editor David · Slashdot

It's FOSS interviewed a software engineer whose long-running open source contributions include Python code for the Arch Linux installer and maintaining packages for NixOS. But "a recent change he made to systemd has pushed him into the spotlight" after he'd added the optional birthDate field for systemd's user database:

Critics saw it not merely as a technical addition, but as a symbolic capitulation to government overreach. A crack in the philosophical foundation of freedom that Linux is built on. What followed went far beyond civil disagreement. Dylan revealed that he faced harassment, doxxing, death threats, and a flood of hate mail. He was forced to disable issues and pull request tabs across his GitHub repositories...

Q: Should FOSS projects adapt to laws they fundamentally disagree with? Because these kinds of laws are certainly in conflict with what a lot of Linux users believe in.

A. Unfortunately, in a lot of cases, the answer is yes — at least for any distribution with corporate backing. The small independent distributions are much more flexible to refuse as a protest.

If we ignore regulations entirely, we risk Linux being something that companies are not willing to contribute to, and Linux may be shipped on less hardware. I'm talking about things like Valve and System76 (despite them very vocally hating these laws). That does not help us; it just lowers the quality of software contributions due to less investment in the platform and makes Linux less accessible to the average person. We need Linux and other free operating systems to remain a viable alternative to closed systems.

Q. Do you think regulations like these will reshape desktop Linux in the next 5-10 years where we might have "compliant Linux" and "Freedom-first Linux"?

A. Unfortunately, yes, to some degree this is likely. I imagine the split will be mostly along the lines of independent distributions and those with corporate backing.

We're already seeing it as far as which distributions plan on implementing some sort of age verification and which ones are not, and that sucks. I'd rather nobody have to deal with this mess at all, but this is the reality of things now. As I said in the previous response, the corporate-backed distributions really have no choice in the matter. Companies are notoriously risk-adverse, but something like Artix or Devuan? Those are small and independent enough where the individual maintainers may be willing to take on more risk.

I was actually thinking about what this would look like if we added it to [Linux system installer] Calamares and chatting about that with the maintainers before that thread got

brigaded by bad actors posting personal information and throwing around insults. I completely support the freedom for the distro maintainers to choose their risk tolerance. If the distribution is based out of Ireland or something (like Linux Mint) without these silly laws in the jurisdiction the developer operates in, I think that we should leave it up to them to make a choice here.

They think the installer should have a date picker with a flag to disable it, and "We can even default it to off, and corporate distributions using Calamares or those not willing to take the risk could flip it on if they need to. That way if maintainers of the distributions do not wish to collect the birth date, they won't have to, and no forking is required to patch it out."

Read more of this story at Slashdot.

The Best Books, Movies, Video Games, and Podcasts to Check Out After Watching ‘Severance’

Jeff Somers · Lifehacker

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From the moment Mark Scout (Adam Scott) first rode an elevator down to his office and became a totally different person, we’ve been obsessed with *Severance*. Over two spectacular seasons, Ben Stiller’s sci-fi satire has explored the banality of corporate culture (and corporate cults), the impact of trauma, and the power of memory—or lack thereof. The story of a group of people who undergo the severance procedure, creating a separate workplace persona called an “Innie” who is essentially a separate individual lacking their outside memories, delivered one of the best finales of all time with its second-season ender “Cold Harbor.”

But it’s been a year since then, and there’s no official word on when we’ll see season three. If you’re jonesing for more of that bleak corporate vibe, mysterious and important work, and surprisingly nuanced commentary on the human condition— and you’ve already explored our list of streamalike shows —allow me to suggest some equally terrific books, movies, video games, and podcasts that will fill that empty space in your head.

The best books like ‘Severance’

Severance packs a lot of literary references into its scripts, adding a dense layer of subtext that makes every storyline richer (and more challenging). Unsurprisingly, there are a lot of choices if you’re looking for a reading experience that will give you similar vibes.

Tell Me an Ending: A Novel

\$13.29 at Amazon

\$20.00 Save \$6.71

\$13.29 at Amazon

\$20.00 Save \$6.71

The Room: A Novel

\$12.84 at Amazon

\$14.00 Save \$1.16

\$12.84 at Amazon

\$14.00 Save \$1.16

The Fold: A Novel

\$14.51 at Amazon

\$21.00 Save \$6.49

\$14.51 at Amazon

\$21.00 Save \$6.49

Several People Are Typing: A GMA Book Club Pick

\$13.35 at Amazon

\$18.00 Save \$4.65

\$13.35 at Amazon

\$18.00 Save \$4.65

\$10.12 at Amazon

\$17.99 Save \$7.87

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One reason *Severance* is so compelling is the question raised by its basic premise: We are the sum of our experiences, so what would we be like if we didn’t have some (or most) of them? In *Tell Me an Ending*, a corporation offers a revolutionary memory-erasing procedure, and customers can choose to either be aware that they had a memory deleted—or not. Around the globe, people struggle with the consequences of removing crucial memories, including one character who slowly realizes he’s deleted the majority of his existence from his own brain.

If you miss the wonderfully creepy vibe of the Macrodata Refinement Department at Lumon Industries, *The Room* is the story for you. Björn is a government worker who strives to be the perfect employee, driven by an almost cultish desire to do everything required of him. When he discovers a strange room in the office—one his coworkers scrupulously pretend isn’t there—he begins spending time in it, apparently staring off into space, talking to himself. The more he does it, the harder his peers try to get him fired—but Björn has a plan to defend himself. And it involves what he’s discovered in the room.

The dual nature of the characters is a major aspect of *Severance*’s appeal—the Innies and Outies share a body, but have diverging personalities and desires that become more and more pronounced (and tragic) as time goes on. In *The Fold*, a man with a photographic memory is asked to investigate a series of odd events around a secret project that appears to have invented teleportation by folding dimensions—with strange side effects for those who walk through the “perfectly safe” portal, including one team member who was apparently driven insane by his experience. It’s a dark sci-fi story about mysterious and important work that is not at all what it seems.

If you love *Severance*’s off-kilter take on corporate life (and

The CISO Struggle: How AI is Changing the Data Security Landscape

Deanna Ritchie · ReadWrite

Generative AI (GenAI) is expanding so quickly that security professionals are struggling to track its impact. Right now, employees are drafting their emails and reports using ChatGPT as their writing assistant, and sales teams are piping customer relationship management (CRM) data directly into AI assistance tools. Some developers are even connecting their code repositories to Copilot. Many teams are embedding GenAI into their daily operations before they've even figured out how to govern it.

The main issue with all of this is the speed at which companies have latched onto GenAI but ignored the development of good security and governance. Chief Information Security Officers, or CISOs, are facing a growing data-security crisis, one that their legacy systems were not built to manage because they were designed in a time when the framework for taking these new concerns into consideration didn't even exist yet.

And while businesses are eager to harness the productivity that GenAI promises, their security teams are often left scrambling to make certain that things like proprietary data, intellectual property, and private or regulated information aren't leaking into the large language models (LLMs) that sustain AI or are otherwise being mishandled by unmonitored AI agents.

The New AI Concern

CISO concerns are not hypothetical. The reality is that companies and organizations are adopting GenAI at such a staggering rate that, according to recent industry analytics, 88% of them have already incorporated generative AI into at least one business function. Such a rapid integration shows how enthusiastic these companies are about AI's potential, but it also highlights how responsible GenAI enablement needs to be a priority. One study found that only 24% of Chief Information Officers (CIOs) and CISOs felt that the necessary governance policies were even in place to properly manage their current AI-related risks.

As a result, the real test for security leaders is how to build the practical guardrails they need to moderate correctly, as well as how to modernize the current oversight so AI adoption doesn't sacrifice security and data protection to greater AI-driven productivity goals.

Re-Architecting in the Age of AI

Currently, data security architecture leans into perimeter defense and endpoint controls. Unfortunately, that is proving increasingly insufficient in an environment where data is being moved, summarized, consumed, and regurgitated by sophisticated, and often third-party, AI services. These older models operated under the assumption that the data flow would always be predictable and manageable at all endpoints. GenAI breaks this pattern by creating new,

and even hidden, pathways for data to pass through the pipeline.

Captain Compliance reports that "ChatGPT and related OpenAI products triggered a wave of GDPR [General Data Protection Regulation] enforcement proceedings beginning in 2023." This and other investigations have led to several new Information Privacy Acts to try to combat the new threat. When employees use a publicly available LLM, they are effectively uploading corporate data to an environment that exists outside the direct control of the organization's security team. Now, even though LLM providers offer better data agreements, such immediate and easy accessibility to AI tools means that "shadow AI" has become an ongoing concern, and that security teams have to treat every AI interaction as a potential data-loss event until they can prove otherwise.

One study by Proofpoint showed that the sheer volume of data being moved through GenAI tools is overwhelming existing data loss prevention (DLP) solutions, mostly because legacy DLP was designed for a world of email and file transfers, not for the high-speed data flow that comes with an AI model. This means security teams need to shift their focus from merely blocking certain suspect actions to fully understanding the context of the data that's being used and the purpose behind each interaction.

The Three Pillars of Security

To more fully contain the new AI-saturated ecosystem, CISOs need to focus on three important pillars:

1. Visibility

You can't govern what you can't see. Organizations need tools that can monitor the data flow going in and out of AI services. This includes not only identifying which AI tools are being used, but also what data is moving around, which will require next-gen data security platforms that can track data lineage across cloud services and other environments.

2. Policy

Old generic acceptable use policies are no longer adequate. Security teams need to collaborate with their legal and compliance department to better design practical rules for GenAI use. This includes classifying data according to its sensitivity and then setting specific rules for how each classification can interact with different AI models.

3. Enforcement

Traditional controls need to be turned into data security management solutions that can enforce policies in real-time. This way, they can empower employees to use GenAI productively while also offering guardrails to prevent accidental or even malicious data exposure. Basically, using AI to secure AI by having the machine learn to identify data usage patterns and classify data sensitivity automatically.

tunnel of mirrors and steel reshapes how space is experienced in new delhi bar

Manav Dangg · *designboom Architecture*

corten and stainless steel clad No Vacancy in New Delhi

For No Vacancy, a bar in New Delhi, India, Manav Dangg, principal architect at Studio Dangg shapes a compact interior into a spatial experience defined by movement, amplifying the long and narrow proportions of the site and allowing the volume to become the central protagonist of the project. A continuous tunnel-like enclosure draws visitors inward, where mirrored surfaces extend perception and soften spatial limits. Corners are softened into curved transitions, while a full-height mirror anchors one end, visually doubling the depth of the space. A continuous bench merges with the wall, guiding movement along the length of the interior.

A corten steel –inspired finish wraps the space in warm, oxidized tones, contrasted by precise stainless steel insertions. Furniture follows the same logic, with leather seating, bouclé backrests, and steel rims introducing tactile variation without disrupting continuity. Color is used sparingly, with sage-green stools providing a subtle accent within an otherwise muted palette.

all images by Avesh Gaur

layered glow shapes the atmosphere

A concealed cove light traces the length of the bench, grazing textured surfaces and emphasizing curvature. Stainless steel elements catch and diffuse small points of light from table lamps and wall sconces, creating a layered glow. Behind the bar, the New Delhi-based architects at Studio Dangg combine backlit acrylic with steel mesh to transform bottle displays into luminous compositions, reinforcing the project's scenographic quality.

The space operates as a community-oriented bar organized around a single focal point. DJs and vinyl artists occupy one end, allowing the entire crowd to orient itself naturally without visual fragmentation. The elongated volume supports this arrangement, producing an intimate, boiler-room-like atmosphere where proximity intensifies both sound and social interaction.

No Vacancy is built on a series of deliberate decisions: embracing limitation, prioritizing movement, and balancing industrial coolness with moments of warmth. The fixed volume becomes an active agent, shaping how visitors enter, gather, and engage. As the tunnel compresses and extends perception through reflection, light, and sound, the project demonstrates how constraint can be translated into spatial intensity.

a full-height mirror anchors one end

a continuous tunnel-like enclosure draws visitors inward

mirrored surfaces extend perception and soften spatial limits

corners are softened into curved transitions

a spatial experience defined by movement

a continuous bench merges with the wall

guiding movement along the length of the interior

embracing limitation, prioritizing movement, and balancing industrial coolness with moments of warmth

demonstrating how constraint can be translated into spatial intensity

the space operates as a community-oriented bar

project info:

name: No Vacancy

architect: Studio Dangg | @studiodangg

location: New Delhi, India

principal architect: Manav Dangg | @manavdangg

designboom has received this project from our DIY submissions feature, where we welcome our readers to submit their own work for publication. see more project submissions from our readers here.

edited by: thomai tsimpou | designboom

The post tunnel of mirrors and steel reshapes how space is experienced in new delhi bar appeared first on designboom | architecture & design magazine .

Beyond Code Review

Mike Loukides · O'Reilly Radar

Not that long ago, we were resigned to the idea that humans would need to inspect every line of AI-generated code. We'd do it personally, code reviews would always be part of a serious software practice, and the ability to read and review code would become an even more important part of a developer's skillset. At the same time, I suspect we all knew that was untenable, that AI would quickly generate much more code than humans could reasonably review. Understanding someone else's code is harder than understanding your own, and understanding machine-generated code is harder still. At some point—and that point comes fairly early on—all the time you saved by letting AI write your code is spent reviewing it. It's a lesson we've learned before; it's been decades since anyone except for a few specialists needed to inspect the assembly code generated by a compiler. And, as Kellan Elliott-McRae has written, it's not clear that code review has ever justified the cost. While sitting around a table inspecting lines of code might catch problems of style or poorly implemented algorithms, code review remains an expensive solution to relatively minor problems.

With that in mind, specification-driven development (SDD) shifts the emphasis from review to verification, from prompting to specification, and from testing to still more testing. The goal of software development isn't code that passes human review; it's systems whose behavior lives up to a well-defined specification that describes what the customer wants. Finding out what the customer needs and designing an architecture to meet those needs requires human intelligence. As Ankit Jain points out in *Latent Space*, we need to make the transition from asking whether the code is written correctly to asking whether we're solving the right problem. Understanding the problem we need to solve is part of the specification process—and it's something that, historically, our industry hasn't done well.

Verifying that the system actually performs as intended is another critical part of the software development process. Does it solve the problem as described in the specification? Does it meet the requirements for what Neal Ford calls “architectural characteristics” or “ilities”: scalability, auditability, performance, and many other characteristics that are embodied in software systems but that can rarely be inferred from looking at the code, and that AI systems can't yet reason about? These characteristics should be captured in the specification. The focus of the software development process moves from writing code to determining what the code should do and verifying that it indeed does what it's supposed to do. It moves from the middle of the process to the beginning and the end. AI can play a role along the way, but specification and verification are where human judgment is most important.

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Drew Breunig and others point out that this is inherently a circular process, not a linear one. A specification isn't something you write at the start of the process and never touch again. It needs to be updated whenever the system's desired behavior changes: whenever a bug fix results in a new test, whenever users clarify what they want, whenever the developers understand the system's goals more deeply. I'm impressed with how agile this process is. It is not the agile of sprints and standups but the agile of incremental development. Specification leads to planning, which leads to implementation, which leads to verification. If verification fails, we update the spec and iterate. Drew has built *Plumb*, a command line tool that can be plugged into Git, to support an automated loop through specification and testing. What distinguishes *Plumb* is its ability to help software developers look at the decisions that resulted in the current version of the software: diffs, of course, but also conversations with AI, the specifications, the plans, and the tests. As Drew says, *Plumb* is intended as an inspiration or a starting point, and it's clearly missing important features—but it's already useful.

Can SDD replace code review? Probably; again, code review is an expensive way to do something that may not be all that useful in the long run. But maybe that's the wrong question. If you don't listen carefully, SDD sounds like a reinvention of the waterfall process: a linear drive from writing a detailed spec to burning thousands of CDs that are stored into a warehouse. We need to listen to SDD itself to ask the right questions: How do we know that a software system solves the right problem? What kinds of tests can verify that the system solves the right problem? When is automated testing inappropriate, and when do we need human engineers to judge a system's fitness? And how can we express all of that knowledge in a specification that leads a language model to produce working software?

We don't place as much value in specifications as we did in the last century; we tend to see spec writing as an obsolete ceremony at the start of a project. That's unfortunate, because we've lost a lot of institutional knowledge about how to write good, detailed specifications. The key to making specifications relevant again is realizing that they're the start of a circular process that continues through verification. The specification is the repository for the project's real goals: what it's supposed to do and why—and those goals necessarily change during the course of a project. A software-driven development loop that runs through testing—not just unit testing but fitness testing, acceptance testing, and human judgment about the results—lays the groundwork for a new kind of process in which humans won't be swamped by reviewing AI-generated code.

Death in the Young

Brendan Foht · *The New Atlantis*

In this sad world of ours, sorrow comes to all; and, to the young, it comes with bitterest agony, because it takes them unawares.

— Abraham Lincoln, Letter to Fanny McCullough , December 23, 1862

In war, those with their lives yet to be lived are also those most urgently needed to fight. It is one of the tragic ironies of conflict. In the U. S. Civil War, the average soldier was 26 and approximately 620,000 soldiers died . In World War I, over 2 million German soldiers died, and 40 percent of German combatants were between 21 and 25 years old. In the Vietnam War, 58,193 American servicemen died — approximately 24 percent of those killed were 20, and roughly 17 percent of those killed were 21 . We comprehend the risk in sending young soldiers off to battle: the abrupt cessation of so much potential and promise. It is no less tragic than the death of sons and daughters in any other context, but at least we understand the possible outcome.

But what of the young who do not fight, who expect to live full lives off the battlefield? Alas, forces beyond their control operate surreptitiously; a few dangerous mutations cause a cell to run awry, errant motorists drive recklessly, malfunctioning plane hardware fails mid-air— all of these cut life short in unexpected ways.

In my brief career, I have already seen patients from infancy to young adulthood fall victim to the cruelty of nature. As physicians we don't feel the shock of such events in the same way as the patients' friends and family. We see the patients, we take care of them, we escort them to their end, and then we move on to take care of the next casualty or convalescent.

Dr. Jon Marc Finamore , a 30-year-old colleague and close friend, upended that sense of detachment for me. Jon and I were in the same class in residency and that created a sense of camaraderie. We shared night and weekend calls along with the traditional weekday rotations. We signed out to each other, always commiserating over one frustrating experience or another. During our time off we mulled over a couple of beers with our other friends, running through stories and talking about our future aspirations in medicine.

It was easy to be friends with Jon; sure, he was kind, but his unwavering jovial manner persisted throughout the most difficult moments of our training, always making a dry, hilarious, and self-effacing joke.

When on-call with him, I can think of multiple instances where he would pitch in to help even if it was not his primary responsibility. On one Thanksgiving a couple of years ago, I was covering consult calls in the hospital and was quickly overwhelmed, all while trying to escape home for festivities that evening. When it was clear I would be stuck,

Jon, without asking, started seeing some of my patients. He simply took on some of the burden for me. I got out on time.

These sorts of gestures were evident elsewhere, too. In a social setting, he would turn to our quieter comrades and ask if they were okay with a particular bar or movie and if they had any preferences, such that no one steamrolled anyone else. He looked after everyone but himself, attentive to the smallest amounts of discomfort or dissatisfaction. Even at his bachelor party, while trying to negotiate the wants and needs of his residency friends and everyone else, he asked a few of us if we were fine going to a particular pub everyone else had suggested.

If this was true of Jon with his friends, it was doubly true of Jon with his patients, who were as dedicated to him as he was to them. We sometimes substituted for each other in clinic, if one of us worked nights that week. I saw many of Jon's patients, some of whom were Spanish-speaking (Jon spoke Spanish), and many of them seemed disappointed when I walked into the exam room. Where was Jon? When would he be back? Could I make sure they see him next time?

And despite his easy-going way, Jon also took his studies seriously. He carried around a notebook with him wherever he went, documenting what he learned and saw. When I took over at the VA hospital after his rotation there, I entered the workroom and saw his diagrams of nervous system motor, sensory, and visual pathways drawn on printer paper sitting on the desk. He never let a moment go to waste; he endlessly fed his curiosity.

Amidst this scintillating and effervescent life, something happened to Jon during our third year of residency. His wife, Erica Finamore, Features Editor at Food Network Magazine and The Pioneer Woman Magazine and Jon's eventual champion, writes in a beautiful and moving essay for *Cosmopolitan* about this sudden change. Jon was unable to speak Spanish. He could not find the words. Moreover, he slept almost 19 hours a day, had trouble with recall of facts and figures. He and Erica went to the emergency room, where the doctors there ordered an MRI of Jon's brain.

The news was not good. Imaging revealed a large brain tumor, known as a glioblastoma multiforme . The malignancy wreaks havoc on the mind and the body. Life expectancy, depending on the genetic mutations of the tumor, ranges from 1 to 3 years. The mutations within Jon's tumor were all bad; it was as aggressive as it could possibly be. He hadn't done anything to cause this. It was probably a sporadic mutation. Nature rolled the die for him and this was the outcome.

I cannot possibly imagine what he felt that evening when he looked at the MRI of his brain and knew his diagnosis. As a neurologist, Jon was au fait with his fate from time zero. He had seen his own patients wilt under the weight of this disease as it took away speech, strength, cognition, and eventually all the pneuma of life, with seizures, hospitalizations, chemotherapy, radiation, and surgery as pit stops

Google's Pixel Buds Pro 2 Are \$60 Off for the Amazon Big Spring Sale

Jake Peterson · Lifehacker

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There are all kinds of earbuds to choose from out there — especially if you aren't dedicated to one specific ecosystem. If you're an Android user, however, and especially if you're a Pixel user, you might find that Google's Pixel Buds Pro are among your best options. Right now, the latest model, the Pixel Buds Pro 2, have a solid 26% discount for Amazon's Big Spring Sale —bringing the price from \$229 down to \$169.

Google Pixel Buds Pro 2

\$169.00 at Amazon

\$229.00 Save \$60.00

\$169.00 at Amazon

\$229.00 Save \$60.00

The Pixel Buds Pro 2 have a number of features you'd expect from earbuds sporting the "Pro" moniker. There's Adaptive Audio, which adjusts the volume based on your environment (if your surroundings get too loud, the volume turns up so you can hear); Loud Noise Protection, which dampens loud noises to protect your hearing; and Active Noise Cancellation. These Pixel Buds Pro are also the first to include a Tensor chip built in, Google's in-house chip. The earbuds use the Tensor A1 chip to power Active Noise Cancellation, which Google says cancels "twice the noise" as the first generation Pixel Buds Pro.

As this is a Google product, and it's 2026, Pixel Buds Pro 2 also have AI features you can use—powered by Gemini, of course. You can use the buds to talk to Gemini Live without picking up your smartphone, answer calls by nodding your head, or have Gemini field your incoming messages, including summarizing long texts (though we know how AI summaries can be).

Google says that Pixel Buds Pro 2 have 12 hours of listening time when Active Noise Cancellation is disabled, and up to 48 hours with the charging case. With Active Noise Cancellation turned on, you get eight hours of listening time, and 30 hours with the charging case. You can pop the earbuds in the case for five minutes to get 1.5 hours of listening time (with noise cancellation off).

In their review, PCMag found the Pixel Buds Pro 2 "excellent," with "strong sound quality and solid noise cancellation in a comfortable design." In their view, the Pixel Buds Pro 2 were definitely best for Pixel users, though all Android users can access the Pixel Buds app for additional customizations. (Sorry, iPhone users.) If you have an Android phone, especially a Pixel, these earbuds are definitely worth a consideration—particularly with the price cut. It's

not the lowest Amazon has had the buds for, but it is the lowest price since January.

Apple AirPods Pro 3 Noise Cancelling Heart Rate Wireless Earbuds

— \$199.00

(List Price \$249.00)

Apple iPad 11" 128GB A16 WiFi Tablet (Blue, 2025)

— \$299.00

(List Price \$349.00)

Samsung Galaxy Tab A11+ 128GB Wi-Fi 11" Tablet (Gray)

— \$209.99

(List Price \$249.99)

Sony WH1000XM6- Best Wireless Noise Canceling Headphones

— \$398.00

(List Price \$459.99)

Apple Watch Series 11 (GPS, 42mm, S/M Black Sport Band)

— \$299.00

(List Price \$399.00)

Blink Video Doorbell Wireless (Newest Model) + Sync Module Core

— \$35.99

(List Price \$69.99)

Fire TV Stick 4K Max Streaming Player With Remote

— \$34.99

(List Price \$59.99)

Amazon Kindle Colorsoft 16GB 7" eReader (Black)

— \$169.99

(List Price \$249.99)

Deals are selected by our commerce team

This Running Store Was Named the Very Best in the U.S. for 2024

TJ Pitre · Trail Runner Magazine

In our increasingly digitized landscape where running shoes and gear can be purchased online and on the cheap, brick-and-mortar running stores are proving as important as ever before.

There are the obvious reasons: an expert can find optimal shoe options for your foot and gait, you can try the shoes on to see if they actually work before purchasing, you're supporting your local economy. And then there are the less obvious reasons, such as the instrumental role local shoe stores play in creating a running community, supporting local causes, and fostering a culture of health and fitness. Plus, visiting your local running store is less about a transactional experience to buy new gear, and more about invigorating your own inspiration for running.

It's a nuance Cathy and Ray Pugsley, husband-and-wife owners of Virginia-based PR Run & Walk, understand deeply. Their passion for empowering others to put one foot in front of the other is why they got into this business. And now their company is the 2024 Running Store of the Year.

"There are many benefits to going to an independent, locally owned store that most people don't even think of," Ray says. "There's the notion that tax dollars stay in your community that many people understand, but beyond that we're hiring people in the local community, we're putting on races, we're creating training programs, we serve as a gathering place, and a place to disseminate information about wellness, and helping people be as happy as they can while exercising. And it's hard to put an exact value on that."

Running has changed a lot over the past 20 years, and so has their business. They started with two stores in 2003 and have since grown to 10 shops. But no matter how much their business expands, the mission remains the same: serving the needs of their local communities. The Pugsleys, who were married in 2001, each come from competitive running backgrounds. And yet their business has been built around promoting health and fitness for all levels of participants, welcoming anyone into their stores who is interested in running or walking.

While PR Run & Walk is in the business of selling running shoes, apparel, and accessories, the Pugsleys have taken pride in fostering life-changing inspiration through local training programs, putting on numerous races, encouraging new runners and walkers to get started, sponsoring regional runner rankings, and supporting local school running programs.

The stores' exceptional customer service, personalized shoe-fitting processes, welcoming atmosphere, and support of their local communities has made the business a beloved community resource through the years. On November 21, PR Run & Walk earned the prestigious national

honor of being named the 2024 Running Store of the Year at The Running Event trade show in Austin, Texas.

"Running is about more than miles—it's about finding our people, our community, and creating connections that last a lifetime," Cathy says. "Life is better when we lift each other up, and this industry's collaborative spirit proves we're all stronger together."

Over 12,500 stores across 29 states were nominated for the honor by customers, employees, and industry professionals. Through a detailed evaluation process, stores were assessed by an industry task force on criteria such as community engagement, sustainability efforts, inclusivity, mentorship opportunities, employee benefits, and innovation. The final determination of winners included secret shopper evaluations of the in-store experience.

"It's truly inspiring to see how these retailers continue to uplift their communities and drive the running industry forward," says Christina Henderson, event director of The Running Event.

RELATED: Shop Small Business Saturday: Why Your Local Running Store Matters

A Hyperlocal Focus

Amid a booming new running population, competition from online retailers and the disruption of Covid-19, PR Run & Walk has continued to flourish. While the pandemic shutdown of 2020 limited its business (and contributed to the closure of its Washington D. C. store), it adapted by doing online shoe-fittings, home deliveries, and outdoor sales events. That galvanized trust in their local communities and became a windfall as committed, lapsed, and new runners helped create a post-pandemic surge of participation.

PR Run & Walk owners Ray and Cathy Pugsley credit their entire staff for being named Running Store of the Year. (Photo: PR Run & Walk)

PR Run & Walk has evolved through the years by capitalizing on advanced technology in its shoe-fitting process, embracing diversity in its 80-person staff and customer base, and going out of its way to celebrate walking for those customers who aren't interested in running. (It rebranded its stores in 2022-2023 from its original name—Potomac River Running—to further embrace walking and general fitness.) In addition to backing local school teams and runners, it also supports the needs of local teachers, first responders, and military members.

The Pugsleys believe shopping at their stores offers customers the best way to find the optimal shoes to match their foot size and shape, as well as gait. Their personalized fitting process includes advanced video gait evaluations, 3D foot-scanning, and shoe-fitting technology, not to mention insights and tips from its knowledgeable staff and a wide range of shoes available in a wide range of sizes and colors.

Stop Closing the Door. Fix the House.

Angie Jones · O'Reilly Radar

The following article originally appeared on Angie Jones's website and is being republished here with the author's permission.

I've been seeing more and more open source maintainers throwing up their hands over AI-generated pull requests. Going so far as to stop accepting PRs from external contributors.

This week we're going to begin automatically closing pull requests from external contributors. I hate this, sorry. pic.twitter.com/85GLG7i1fU

— tldraw (@tldraw) January 15, 2026

Ghostty is getting an updated AI policy. AI assisted PRs are now only allowed for accepted issues. Drive-by AI PRs will be closed without question. Bad AI drivers will be banned from all future contributions. If you're going to use AI, you better be good. <https://t.co/AJRX79S8XD>

— Mitchell Hashimoto (@mitchellh) January 22, 2026

AI is killing Open Source and it's saddening. Basically, a bunch of people who now believe they're geniuses because of LLMs have been spamming OSS projects with junk submissions causing some maintainers to limit contributions from the general public.

— ASH (@ahmxrd) February 7, 2026

If you're an open source maintainer, you've felt this pain. We all have. It's frustrating reviewing PRs that not only ignore the project's coding conventions but also are riddled with AI slop.

But yo, what are we doing?! Closing the door on contributors isn't the answer. Open source maintainers don't want to hear this, but this is the way people code now, and you need to do your part to prepare your repo for AI coding assistants.

I'm a maintainer on goose which has more than 300 external contributors. We felt this frustration early on, but instead of pushing well-meaning contributors away, we did the work to help them contribute with AI responsibly.

1. Tell humans how to use AI on your project

We created a HOWTOAI.md file as a straightforward guide for contributors on how to use AI tools responsibly when working on our codebase. It covers things like:

What AI is good for (boilerplate, tests, docs, refactoring) and what it's not (security critical code, architectural changes, code you don't understand)

The expectation that you are accountable for every line you submit, AI-generated or not

How to validate AI output before opening a PR: build it, test it, lint it, understand it

Being transparent about AI usage in your PRs

This welcomes AI PRs but also sets clear expectations. Most contributors want to do the right thing, they just need to know what the right thing is.

And while you're at it, take a fresh look at your CONTRIBUTING.md too. A lot of the problems people blame on AI are actually problems that always existed, AI just amplified them. Be specific. Don't just say "follow the code style"; say what the code style is. Don't just say "add tests"; show what a good test looks like in your project. The better your docs are, the better both humans and AI agents will perform.

2. Tell the agents how to work on your project

Contributors aren't the only ones who need instructions. The AI agents do too.

We have an AGENTS.md file that AI coding agents can read to understand our project conventions. It includes the project structure, build commands, test commands, linting steps, coding rules, and explicit "never do this" guardrails.

When someone points their AI agent at our repo, the agent picks up these conventions automatically. It knows what to do and how to do it, what not to touch, how the project is structured, and how to run tests to check their work.

You can't complain that AI-generated PRs don't follow your conventions if you never told the AI what your conventions are.

3. Use AI to review AI

Investing in an AI code reviewer as the first touchpoint for incoming PRs has been a game changer.

I already know what you're thinking... They suck too. LOL, fair. But again, you have to guide the AI. We added custom instructions so the AI code reviewer knows what we care about.

We told it our priority areas: security, correctness, architecture patterns. We told it what to skip: style and formatting issues that CI already catches. We told it to only comment when it has high confidence there's a real issue, not just nitpick for the sake of it.

Now, contributors get feedback before a maintainer ever looks at the PR. They can clean things up on their own. By the time it reaches us, the obvious stuff is already handled.

4. Have good tests

No, seriously. I've been telling y'all this for YEARS. Anyone who tells you their pipeline should also be doing the heavy lifting on quality checks so you don't have to. Linting, formatting,

A White Doctor Goes to Africa

Brendan Foht · *The New Atlantis*

“I am departing totally convinced,” the great Russian playwright Anton Chekhov wrote to a professional acquaintance in March of 1890, “that my trip will yield a valuable contribution neither to literature nor to science.” Chekhov prepared to leave for Sakhalin Island, a distant part of the Russian Empire north of Japan filled with convicts and criminal exiles. If this trip would offer nothing to literature or science, what could Chekhov, a physician and member of the literati, gain from this sojourn? He knew he would see suffering and pain there, the nadir of human existence. Why descend on that path?

His decision perplexes us further when we realize that Chekhov experienced misery and anguish his entire life. His father flogged him and his siblings regularly. In 1875 he came down with a severe infection of his abdomen. His brothers left home against their father’s wishes to work in Moscow, leaving Anton to absorb his father’s beatings. Meanwhile the family shop went bankrupt and Anton’s father fled, leaving his mother to face his debts. Anton’s brother, Nikolai, would die at a young age of tuberculosis. And as Anton became a physician and eventually attained success as a writer, he developed pulmonary tuberculosis, too. And yet, Chekhov departed for Sakhalin Island.

In the eponymous book on his trip, *Sakhalin Island*, Chekhov fastidiously describes what he sees: the people he meets, the geography of the landscape, the weather, and the suffering of the exiles. Yet he ignores our most burning question: Why give up precious time — especially given his deadly illness — for months in the bowels of humanity? What drives one to do this?

Though he does not directly address this in his book, his March, 1890 letter quoted above hints at an answer: “Even assuming that the journey will yield me precisely nothing — nonetheless, however, might there not occur, during the entire journey, two or three of the kind of days which I’ll recall my whole life with delight or bitterness?” Such an excursion might provide moments of invaluable self-reflection. And they might bring with them a sense of gratitude, a reminder of great deeds and what matters in life. He clarifies,

No longer than 25 or 30 years ago our very own Russians, while exploring Sakhalin, achieved astonishing feats, for which a human being might be idolized, but we don’t need all this, we don’t even know who these people were, but only sit gazing at four walls and complaining that God has created mankind so imperfectly.

A trip to Sakhalin would also shake Chekhov from the morass of daily life in which he found himself.

Chekhov also sought to expose the impeachable offenses committed at Sakhalin:

From the books which I have read and am reading now, it’s clear that we have allowed millions of people to rot in prisons, to rot for no purpose, without any consideration and in a barbarous manner; we have driven people tens of thousands of versts through the cold in shackles, infected them with syphilis, perverted them, multiplied the number of criminals, and put all the blame on to red-nosed prison overseers.

Here is Chekhov’s chance to reveal such barbarism, to see and understand what life is like beyond the confines of European Russia, to reflect on his own life, to appreciate what was done to build such an outpost and to shame those who turned it into the festering residence of the Demogorgon. And so, at the age of 30, sick with tuberculosis and the knowledge that he might soon die, Chekhov undertook his brutal journey.

After years of training, lassitude overtakes young resident doctors for a surfeit of reasons: exhaustion with long hours, one’s own feeling of ignorance, meager pay, and the steady push and pull from patients, colleagues, hospital administration, nursing, and life beyond the inpatient wards. Everyone wants something from you, an order in the computer for Tylenol, another note on top of the hundreds of others you’ve written during residency, another training module for HIPAA compliance laws or electronic health record training. These meager requests accumulate quickly and trap us in a morass of bureaucracy and mindless tasks.

American medicine piles on such red tape for some good reasons. In serious academic medical centers the department chairs rightfully build in layers of support for trainees. Before making a decision about a patient, a junior resident speaks with a senior resident and then the senior resident consults with a fellow and then the fellow talks to the attending physician. In other words, strata exist to ensure that we make the right decisions. Second, nurses add another layer of protection — a good, experienced nurse will double check a physician’s decision or order; the same thing goes with a pharmacist who releases the medication to the nurse. Moreover, some of our patients are well-educated and curious and ask us to explain our decisions. All this leads to better care. In one study from 2018, patients with all levels of complex medical illnesses had better outcomes at academic medical centers.

On the other hand, because of this layering, trainees often feel dispensable. Whether true or not, a stratified system makes the decision and reasoning of one person seem less relevant. I am not arguing that residents don’t matter. In fact, they matter quite a lot, as do their decisions. But it can seem, in the thick of it, that they don’t.

Furthermore, in a system like ours, the immediate availability of lab tests and imaging creates a sense of security and reliance on powers beyond one’s own intellect. If we’re uncertain about the exam and history we simply order an advanced radiologic study. Such blessed resources, alas, distort our reasoning. Consequently, we practice medicine in a defensive way, in order “not to miss something.” This

10 Shows Like ‘The Comeback’ You Should Watch Next

Ross Johnson · Lifehacker

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Valerie Cherish is back, and not a moment too soon. Twenty years after a modestly rated but absolutely brilliant first season, mega-*cringe* Hollywood satire *The Comeback* has returned to HBO for one more painfully embarrassing season (complimentary) Co-created by and starring Lisa Kudrow, it's the hilarious, dark, and occasionally moving story of a C-list celebrity determined to stay in the limelight at whatever cost.

Valerie Cherish—clueless, egotistical, and all-too-human—is one of TV's indelible characters, simultaneously a victim of ageism, misogyny, and celebrity culture, and also a woman who doesn't care about any of that provided she can find a way to scrabble to the top. Likewise, these 10 shows spotlight women (mostly) of a certain age navigating career challenges with...mixed results.

Hacks (2021 –)

On the surface, Valerie Cherish and Deborah Vance don't have all that much in common, but they often feel like two sides of a coin in the ways in which they battle, and concede to, the pressures of being a woman in modern show business. *Hacks* finds 25-year-old writer Ava (Hannah Einbinder) struggling to get her career back on track after getting cancelled over a tweet. She reluctantly takes a job with Deborah Vance (Jean Smart), a comedy trailblazer who remains popular with an older Vegas crown, but whose career is largely on autopilot. They're an entirely mismatched pair, but their chemistry is ultimately explosive, with Jean Smart doing some of the best work of her incredible career as the often deeply unlikeable Vance, and Einbinder more than holding her own in return. It's funny, bitchy, and surprisingly moving when it wants to be. Stream *Hacks* on HBO Max .

Hacks (2021 –)

Girls5Eva (2021 – 2024)

The premise is very much about a comeback: A very '90s group (Sara Bareilles, Busy Philipps, Paula Pell, and Renée Elise Goldsberry) who made it big very briefly with exactly one hit song gets its own shot at a career resurgence (they're Girls5Eva because they expected to be in the game “longer than 4 ever”—turned out, not so much; also there used to be a fifth member, but she died in a tragic infinity pool accident). After an up-and-coming rapper samples one of their old hits, the band reunites to try to find new relevancy in the 2020s. It doesn't go great! Tina Fey is one of the executive producers, and the (very fun) '90s-inspired original music was composed and written for the show by the creators. Stream Girls5Eva on Peacock and Netflix .

Girls5Eva (2021 – 2024)

at Peacock

at Peacock

Veep (2012 – 2019)

There's a sweet vulnerability to Valerie Cherish absent from pretty much anyone in *Veep* , but the air of cringeworthy desperation hangs heavy over both shows. *Veep* asks: What if the very worst people imaginable had control of all the levers of power in America? What would that be like? In the highly satirical and in no way politically relevant series, Julia Louis-Dreyfus brilliantly plays Vice President Selina Meyer: part icon, part worst-case-scenario for the feminist dream. The supporting cast consists almost entirely of entitled rich people climbing over each other for infinitesimal extra bits of power while trying to appear as folk heroes to the rubes (us voters). It's one of the funniest shows ever on TV, with the nastiest put-downs...if you can handle the fact that history has overtaken it in favor of a reality that's even more absurd. Stream *Veep* on HBO Max.

Veep (2012 – 2019)

at HBO Max

at HBO Max

The Studio (2025 –)

Industry exec Matt Remick (*Comeback* vet Seth Rogen) loves movies, and when he signs on for a high-profile role at the fictional Continental Studios, he feels like his time has come. He aims to make a real difference in returning an increasingly IP-driven movie industry to its creative roots. —until about a minute into his new job, when the CEO (Bryan Cranston) reveals his first order of business will be marketing the *Kool-Aid Man Movie* . Hollywood satires of yore have focused on the industry as one that eats people up and spits them out, but the spin here is that Remick yearns for those good old days, much as Valerie can never quite seem to move forward. The late Catherine O'Hara, Ike Barinholtz, Chase Sui Wonders (*Bodies Bodies Bodies*), and Kathryn Hahn also star, and like *The Comeback* , the show boasts a long list of celebrity cameos. Stream *The Studio* on Apple TV+ .

The Studio (2025 –)

at Apple TV+

at Apple TV+

Enlightened (2011 – 2013)

Before *The White Lotus* , Mike White co-created (with star Laura Dern) this beloved, if short-lived, comedy-drama about a middle-aged woman who has a complete mental breakdown following a demotion at the job to which she's devoted her life. Following a two-month stay in an holistic treatment facility, Dern's Amy Jellicoe becomes determined to approach life with a new perspective, focusing on medi-

this monolithic café in south korea is designed to evoke an ancient fortress

kat barandy | designboom · designboom Architecture

Monologue Café: A colossal sculpture in the landscape

Korean studio SOSOKKI ANAC takes to a forested landscape in Gangwon-do to design this Monologue Café as a series of angular brick volumes. The monolithic structure rises from the ground in sharp, deliberate formations. The building reads as a continuous mass, its surfaces folded and inclined, with each plane catching light differently across the day.

Set along a quiet edge of water and low vegetation, the project avoids a single, fixed viewpoint. As visitors move around it, the café shifts in profile, sometimes appearing compact and vertical, elsewhere stretched and low against the terrain. The reddish brick facade gives the structure a consistent material presence, while the geometry introduces variation through depth, shadow, and projection.

images © Seokgue Hong

SOSOKKI ANAC evokes a fortress

SOSOKKI ANAC, the architects behind the Monologue Café, begin the design with a speculative concept: a monastery imagined from a time before a reset of the world. This narrative is translated into architecture through the use of layered, faceted forms that suggest accumulation rather than composition. Each volume feels placed in relation to another to build a sense of density and continuity across the site.

References to a monumental boundary condition inform the project's massing, with thick walls and abrupt angles reinforcing a sense of separation and threshold. These gestures are expressed through brick planes that sculpturally tilt, fold, and intersect, thus creating moments where the building reads as both solid and cut.

Monologue Café stands in a forested landscape in Korea as a sculptural brick structure

Interior spaces shaped by light and section

Interiors shift to an atmosphere of pale surfaces and filtered light. Sloped walls and narrow sections guide movement through the space, creating a sequence of compressed and expanded areas. Seating is arranged along elongated corridors, where tables align with angled windows that frame views outward to trees and ground cover.

Large triangular openings define key moments within the café. These apertures bring in daylight with precision, casting changing patterns across the interior surfaces. The geometry of the openings echoes the exterior form, establishing continuity between inside and outside while also directing attention toward the surrounding landscape.

the building shifts in form depending on movement around its angular volumes

folded brick planes create depth through shadow and a sense of layered mass

the design draws from the concept of a monastery from a forgotten civilization

thick walls and sharp geometries evoke the feeling of a fortress

interior spaces are defined by sloped walls and elongated corridors

materials remain restrained with pale surfaces contrasting the exterior brick mass

project info:

name: Monologue Café

architect: SOSOKKI ANAC | @soso_ant101

location: Gangwon-do, South Korea

lead architects: Gi-tae Chung

technical team: WA20 Architects

general contractor: Starsis

landscape architecture: Natural space

area: 455 square meters

completion: 2025

photography: © Seokgue Hong

The post this monolithic café in south korea is designed to evoke an ancient fortress appeared first on designboom | architecture & design magazine .

VUILD's 'prewood' project tests how modular timber can adapt to tight urban sites in tokyo

kat barandy | designboom · designboom Architecture

prewood: a compact timber insertion in tokyo

In Tokyo, VUILD completes prewood, a compact timber building that occupies a narrow urban gap with a precise, modular approach. Set within a dense streetscape, the project fits between neighboring structures with a quiet confidence, its vertical cedar facade introducing a distinct texture while maintaining the rhythm of the street.

The exterior reads as a stacked composition of wooden panels, articulated through subtle shifts in depth and angled cuts. Openings are placed with restraint, offering glimpses of activity inside while preserving privacy along the tight frontage. The material remains untreated, allowing the cedar to weather gradually, its surface expected to shift in tone over time in response to the city's climate.

Prewood, designed by VUILD, occupies a narrow site within a dense Tokyo streetscape | image © Hayato Kurobe

vuild designs modules for reuse

At the core of prewood is a construction system developed by the team at VUILD that treats the building as a set of discrete wooden modules. Each unit is designed for disassembly, allowing the structure to be taken apart and relocated in the future. This approach extends the lifespan of the material beyond a single site, aligning the design with a broader consideration of resource cycles.

The modules are stacked vertically, forming a compact volume that maximizes usable floor area within the constraints of the plot. Digital modeling tools were used to define thousands of screw positions, translating directly into fabrication data. On site, assembly proceeded with a high level of precision, supported by 3D-printed guides that ensured consistent alignment across each connection.

the cedar facade introduces depth through subtle shifts and angled cuts | image © Hayato Kurobe

interior sequencing and spatial compression

Inside, prewood organizes its program through a series of split levels that expand the perception of space within a limited footprint. Service elements are concentrated toward the front, freeing the remaining areas for seating and circulation. The vertical movement between levels introduces variation in ceiling height and perspective, shaping a sequence that feels continuous yet differentiated.

The interior palette is restrained, with plaster walls and exposed timber surfaces defining the atmosphere. Light enters through carefully positioned openings, grazing the surfaces and emphasizing the grain of the wood. In the upper levels, a semi-private zone supports small gatherings,

while a rooftop terrace offers a moment of openness within the surrounding density.

openings are positioned to balance light access with privacy along the street | image © Hayato Kurobe

construction logic and urban timber application

The building's structural system responds directly to the constraints of its site. With limited space for scaffolding, the modular components enabled rapid assembly, completing the primary structure within a short timeframe. The process reduced reliance on specialized carpentry, instead relying on a coordinated system that could be executed with standard construction labor.

Material choices also address regulatory and environmental considerations. Located within a fire prevention district, prewood integrates cross-laminated timber ceilings designed to perform under fire exposure. The use of cedar panels, combined with ventilation gaps and protected end grains, supports durability while maintaining the material's natural finish. Through this approach, VUILD positions prewood as a working example of urban timber construction adapted to dense city conditions.

the building is composed of stacked wooden modules designed for disassembly | image © Hayato Kurobe

each module can be relocated to extend the lifecycle of the structure | image © Tomoyuki Kusunose

split level interiors increase usable space within a compact footprint | image © Tomoyuki Kusunose

project info:

name: Prewood

architect: VUILD | @vuild_architects

location: Nihonbashi-Kayabacho, Chuo-ku, Tokyo, Japan

structural, environmental engineering: Arup

construction: Atelier Umi

completion: 2025

photography: © Tomoyuki Kusunose, Hayato Kurobe

The post VUILD's 'prewood' project tests how modular timber can adapt to tight urban sites in tokyo appeared first on designboom | architecture & design magazine .

Light enters through carefully positioned openings, grazing the surfaces and emphasizing the grain of the wood.

kat barandy | designboom

This Surprisingly Powerful Compressed Air Duster Is 27% Off Today

Stephen Johnson · *Lifehacker*

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Are you still dusting off your electronics with disposable cans of compressed air? Get with the times, man. All the cool people are using rechargeable air dusters like this one. I love mine so much, and I think you will too—and it's on sale for 27% off during Amazon's Big Spring Sale.

WOLFBOX MF70 Compressed Air Duster-110000 RPM Electric Air Duster with Extended Runtime, 3-Speed Rechargeable Air Blower for Keyboard, Computer, Camera, Car, Home, 5 Nozzles

\$43.99 at Amazon

\$59.99 Save \$16.00

\$43.99 at Amazon

\$59.99 Save \$16.00

Seriously, you really need this thing, even if you don't think you do. For a one-time purchase, you can have endless compressed air, and blow the dust off anything you want to for the foreseeable future. It's so much better than compressed air cans: It doesn't get cold in your hand, it makes a satisfying high-pitched whining noise, and it never runs out of propellant. You just recharge it and you're good to go blow. It doesn't create the waste of spent compressed air cans either.

I got mine for Christmas, and I was skeptical at first. It's small enough to fit in your hand, so how could it have the blowing power of a can of compressed air? A couple pulls on the trigger prove it's better than compressed air. The motor's top speed is 110,000 rpm, more than enough power to blast the gunk out of electronics, all the little crevices in your car, air filters, and anything else that needs dusting.

I use mine so often that I have started giving them out as gifts. It's the perfect for any practical person—the kind of tool you wouldn't think of buying for yourself, but that you'll use all the time.

Our Best Editor-Vetted Amazon Big Spring Sale Deals Right Now

Apple AirPods Pro 3 Noise Cancelling Heart Rate Wireless Earbuds

— \$199.00

(List Price \$249.00)

Apple iPad 11" 128GB A16 WiFi Tablet (Blue, 2025)

— \$299.00

(List Price \$349.00)

Samsung Galaxy Tab A11+ 128GB Wi-Fi 11" Tablet (Gray)

— \$209.99

(List Price \$249.99)

Sony WH1000XM6- Best Wireless Noise Canceling Headphones

— \$398.00

(List Price \$459.99)

Apple Watch Series 11 (GPS, 42mm, S/M Black Sport Band)

— \$299.00

(List Price \$399.00)

Blink Video Doorbell Wireless (Newest Model) + Sync Module Core

— \$35.99

(List Price \$69.99)

Fire TV Stick 4K Max Streaming Player With Remote

— \$34.99

(List Price \$59.99)

Amazon Kindle Colorsoft 16GB 7" eReader (Black)

— \$169.99

(List Price \$249.99)

Deals are selected by our commerce team

It's so much better than compressed air cans: It doesn't get cold in your hand, it's makes a satisfying high-pitched whining noise, and it never runs out of propellant.

Stephen Johnson

What the FCC's Router Ban Could Mean for You

Emily Long · Lifehacker

The U. S. government is banning the importation of new routers made overseas, meaning consumers will no longer be able to purchase devices from many popular manufacturers. On Monday, the Federal Communications Commission (FCC) added all consumer-grade routers produced abroad to its "Covered List" of communications equipment that poses an "unacceptable risk to the national security of the United States or the security and safety of United States persons." The agency specifically cited the exploitation of foreign-made routers in the Volt, Flax, and Salt Typhoon cyberattacks.

But the thing is, the vast majority of routers are manufactured overseas. So where does that leave you?

What does the FCC router ban cover?

The FCC's order bans the import of "all consumer-grade routers produced in foreign countries." While there is no list of specific companies or devices covered by this ban, at least 60% of home routers in the U. S. are estimated to come from China—and almost none are made here, a notable exception being Starlink's Wifi router. (The ban also covers routers designed by U. S. companies but manufactured abroad.)

There could be exceptions to the ban in the future, as the federal government will grant "conditional approval" to companies that provide details about their

operations, including information about corporate structure, manufacturing and supply chains, and plans to "establish or expand" production in the U. S. But that's all up in the air at this point.

This isn't the first step the federal government has taken to ban devices made by companies with foreign ties, including routers. Late last year, several agencies, including the Departments of Commerce, Homeland Security, Justice, and Defense, proposed a ban on future sales of TP-Link routers following a review that began during the Biden administration. Other bans include sales of antivirus software made by Russia's Kaspersky Labs and telecom devices from Huawei and ZTE. The FCC also recently banned foreign-made drones for similar security reasons.

What the ban means for your router

The FCC's action does not affect existing routers, so if you have a device made by a foreign company, you can keep using it as normal. If you're currently in the market for a new router, there's no rush—retailers will also continue to be able to sell and import all routers previously approved for sale through FCC's equipment authorization process.

However, since the ban covers the majority of companies that make routers U. S. consumers buy, in the future you won't be able to upgrade to a newly released device from foreign manufacturers like TP-Link and Netgear unless those models receive conditional

World's Smallest QR Code - Smaller Than Bacteria - Could Store Data for Centuries

EditorDavid · Slashdot

"Scientists have created a microscopic QR code so tiny it can only be seen with an electron microscope," reports Science Daily. It's "smaller than most bacteria and now officially a world record."

"But this isn't just about size; it's about durability. By engraving data into ultra-stable ceramic materials, the team has opened the door to storing information that could last for centuries or even millennia without needing power or maintenance."

Scientists at TU Wien, working with data storage company Cerabyte, produced a QR code measuring just 1.98 square micrometers... officially confirmed and recorded in the Guinness Book of Records...

Each pixel measures just 49 nanometers, which is about ten times smaller than the wavelength of visible light. As a result, the pattern is completely invisible under normal conditions and cannot be resolved using visible light. However, when viewed with an electron microscope, the QR code can be clearly and reliably read. The storage capacity is also impressive. More than 2 terabytes of data could fit within the area of a single A4 sheet of paper using this approach...

This work points toward a more sustainable future for data storage, where information can be preserved securely for the long term with minimal energy use. "We live in the information age, yet we store our knowl-

edge in media that are astonishingly short-lived," says Alexander Kirnbaue (from the thin film materials science division at Vienna's Tu Wein research university). "With ceramic storage media, we are pursuing a similar approach to that of ancient cultures, whose inscriptions we can still read today..."

"We now aim to use other materials, increase writing speeds, and develop scalable manufacturing processes so that ceramic data storage can be used not only in laboratories but also in industrial applications."

Read more of this story at Slashdot.

As a result, the pattern is completely invisible under normal conditions and cannot be resolved using visible light.

EditorDavid

Xbox Partner Preview showcase March 2026 - here's everything announced

Matt Wales · Eurogamer

What better way to celebrate a Thursday than another Xbox Partner Preview showcase? Yes, it's that time again when Microsoft turns to its chums and offers them the spotlight; a chance to show the world what they've been working on. As usual, that means a mix of bigger third-party games and some smaller, but no less enticing indie treats - and an eclectic bunch it was too! We got an announcement for a juicy Stalker 2 expansion, a brand-new Serious Sam game, tantalising new Stranger Than Heaven details, a new one from Atomfall developer Rebellion, an Xbox release window for Hades 2 and Dispatch, and even some Bluey! There's plenty more besides, though, and you'll find everything announced below....

[Read more](#)

ANALYSIS

Sucker Punch is peak Zack Snyder, for better or worse

Jesse Hassenger · Polygon

There may be Zack Snyder movies more notorious than Sucker Punch — particularly those that pertain to Batman and/or Superman and/or their mothers' shared first name — but no Snyder movie has bombed harder at the box office than his action-fantasy-psychodrama. (Yes, even the one about warring owls did better.) Perhaps not coincidentally, Sucker Punch, which takes place simultaneously in a corrupt mental institution, a gangster-run brothel, and an impossibly vast fantasy battle-scape, is also the only Snyder movie not based on pre-existing materials to receive a wide theatrical release. Its flop was a sign that, for as much mainstream success and cult adoration as the filmmaker has enjoyed on various projects, there are limits to his fandom, and maybe also his imagination.

You Can Finally Have Two WhatsApp Accounts on Your iPhone

Khamosh Pathak · Lifehacker

WhatsApp just announced a slew of updates for iPhone users, playing catch-up with some of the features that have existed on Android for years. With this update, iPhone users can expect multiple accounts, easy cross-platform transfers, an option to only clear the media from chats, and, of course, a couple of Meta AI features to round things off. According to WhatsApp, the update is rolling out now and will be available to everyone soon—though as it's a slow rollout, it might take time before it's live on your iPhone.

iPhone users can finally have two WhatsApp accounts at once

The biggest update here is the addition of multi-account support, something that WhatsApp has been testing on iPhone since last January, and a feature that has been live on Android since 2023. Now, just like Android, you can use two WhatsApp accounts on your iPhone: perhaps one for work, and one for personal use. But because this is WhatsApp, the second account will need a separate phone number (that's when eSIM is going to be helpful). Once they are set up, you will get notifications and messages from both accounts, and you can switch between the active account from the Profile menu in the tab bar.

iPhone to Android chat transfer gets easier

WhatsApp just made transferring your chats between two phones much easier. It all happens over wifi now (previously you needed to connect using a USB-C cable). On your iPhone, go to Settings > Chats > Transfer chat history > Transfer to Android to get started. Make sure that your iPhone is unlocked, and when prompted, scan a QR code, and connect to a stable wifi network.

Free up space without deleting complete chats

Usually, it's the photos and videos that take up the most space on WhatsApp. The app has a dedicated storage management tool that will delete images and videos in bulk, but now, WhatsApp is bringing it directly into your conversations. Following the update, you'll find a Manage Storage option in every thread. You can select all the media to delete with a tap, while keeping all your text messages, links, and documents safe.

WhatsApp has new sticker suggestions

WhatsApp wants you to switch from regular emojis to its animated stickers. When you type commonly used emojis (say, the heart emoji), it will suggest stickers instead (a pulsating, red heart). You can tap on a sticker to swap out the emoji.

WhatsApp has new AI features for you to ignore

It wouldn't be a Meta update without the addition of new Meta AI features. WhatsApp is updating its Writing Help

feature, which it introduced last year. Writing Help takes your message and suggests a couple of revised versions to replace it with, each in different tones, and all processed locally using WhatsApp's Private Processing feature. Now, WhatsApp can directly draft a reply to a message based on the conversation. This too happens locally, and the chat remains private. Lastly, you can now use Meta AI to touch up photos before sending them off in WhatsApp. You can remove distracting objects, change the background, or apply a different style to the photo.

Some of My Favorite Milwaukee Tools Come With a Free Battery Right Now

Becca Lewis · Lifehacker

We may earn a commission from links on this page. Deal pricing and availability subject to change after time of publication.

One of the most expensive parts of a personal tool kit is the batteries, especially if you want to use multiple tools simultaneously without having to swap the battery each time you change tools. Moving seamlessly between drilling pilot holes and driving screws can save you time on your DIY projects, but the cost of extra batteries can add up. These deals from Home Depot are a good way to save more than 50% on a battery and tool combo if you want to expand your Milwaukee set.

Battery combo

18-volt Milwaukee six-amp-hour battery two-pack

Free extra battery with purchase

\$299.00 at Home Depot

\$439.00 Save \$140.00

\$299.00 at Home Depot

\$439.00 Save \$140.00

If you use bigger Milwaukee 18-volt tools like a circular saw, or use a Milwaukee inverter in your emergency kit for temporary emergency power, a few extra six-amp-hour batteries are helpful to have around, but the higher capacity batteries can be expensive. The two-pack of 18-volt Milwaukee six-amp-hour batteries is on sale for \$299, 32% off its regular price. When you open the link to the two-pack, you'll see a "free gift with purchase" menu to the right, and you can select a third six-amp-hour battery from this menu. Once you add the battery, the discount is applied in your cart for a total savings of 53% off.

Tool combos

I use my Milwaukee 18-volt random orbital sander daily when I'm working on furniture and other projects. Having a cordless sander is more convenient because you don't have to drag the cord around when you're working on delicate projects and you can bring it with you wherever you want to work, making it perfect for outdoor woodworking as well. The Milwaukee 18-volt random orbital sander is on sale for \$229 and it comes with a free six-amp-hour 18-volt battery when you select it in the "free gift with purchase" menu, saving you about 46% on the bundle. On this bundle, as with the other two tool bundles, you'll need an 18-volt Milwaukee charger to use the battery.

Once you add the battery, the discount is applied in your cart for a total savings of 53% off.

Becca Lewis

My Milwaukee oscillating multitool has saved many of my household projects because of its versatility. I used mine when I needed to replace the drain in my 115-year-old Craftsman's bathroom sink to cut through the plaster and lathe, to cut some PVC components, to trim the drain pipe where it came out from the wall, to trim a patch I installed, and to sand over some places after I patched the wall. The 18-volt Milwaukee oscillating multitool is \$249, and right now, it comes with a free 18-volt, six-amp-hour battery when you select it in the "free gift with purchase" menu, saving you around 44% on the set.

18-volt Milwaukee oscillating multitool

Free battery with purchase

\$249.00 at Home Depot

\$249.00 at Home Depot

I use my 6 1/2" Milwaukee circular saw frequently to make quick rip cuts or in places I can't use a table saw. Battery technology has come a long way since I first started using a cordless circular saw and I had to change out my battery every 20 minutes or so. With larger capacity batteries, you can use your cordless circular saw for several hours before needing to replace the battery, depending on the thickness and density of the material you're cutting. The Milwaukee 18-volt, 6 1/2" cordless circular saw is \$229, and it comes with a free six-amp-hour battery when you select it in the "free gift with purchase" menu, saving you about 46% on the combo.

Our Best Editor-Vetted Amazon Big Spring Sale Deals Right Now

Apple AirPods Pro 3 Noise Cancelling Heart Rate Wireless Earbuds

— \$199.00

(List Price \$249.00)

Apple iPad 11" 128GB A16 WiFi Tablet (Blue, 2025)

— \$299.00

(List Price \$349.00)

Samsung Galaxy Tab A11+ 128GB Wi-Fi 11" Tablet (Gray)

— \$209.99

(List Price \$249.99)

Sony WH1000XM6- Best Wireless Noise Canceling Headphones

These Are the Best Laptop Deals I've Seen During Amazon's Big Spring Sale

Jake Peterson · Lifehacker

We may earn a commission from links on this page. Deal pricing and availability subject to change after time of publication.

Amazon's Big Spring Sale is in full swing this week. If you take a look at the "Laptops" section of Amazon's Big Spring Sale page, you'll find seemingly endless options available at a discount. That doesn't mean these are all deals worth considering, however. There are a lot of laptops out there, and not all of them going to be right for you (or most people). As such, I've looked at Amazon's wares, and found some deals that really seem worth considering.

A rule of thumb with deals like these: If you've never heard of the company before, be extremely cautious. There are laptop manufacturers that have been in the game for years, and know how to ship a product that works. If you see a huge discount on a laptop from a no-name company, that should be a red flag. That's not to say all start-ups and new companies should be avoided; just do your research before buying a computer.

M4 MacBook Air (15-inch)

\$1,149.00 at Amazon

\$1,399.00 Save \$250.00

\$1,149.00 at Amazon

\$1,399.00 Save \$250.00

Samsung Galaxy Book 5 Pro 360

\$1,199.99 at Amazon

\$1,699.99 Save \$500.00

\$1,199.99 at Amazon

\$1,699.99 Save \$500.00

HP EliteBook 6 G1i

\$1,899.98 at Amazon

\$2,799.00 Save \$899.02

\$1,899.98 at Amazon

\$2,799.00 Save \$899.02

ASUS TUF F16

\$999.99 at Amazon

\$1,299.99 Save \$300.00

\$999.99 at Amazon

\$1,299.99 Save \$300.00

ASUS ROG Strix G18

\$1,394.99 at Amazon

\$1,699.99 Save \$305.00

\$1,394.99 at Amazon

\$1,699.99 Save \$305.00

Lenovo Legion 5i

\$1,469.99 at Amazon

\$1,669.99 Save \$200.00

\$1,469.99 at Amazon

\$1,669.99 Save \$200.00

SEE 3 MORE

M4 15-inch MacBook Air

If you're in the market for a large yet portable laptop, the MacBook Air is a great buy. While Apple's newest model has the M5 chip, the M4 version is more than capable to buy instead—especially when you can save some money.

During Amazon's Big Spring Sale, you can pick up the 15-inch M4 MacBook Air for \$1,149 . That's \$150 cheaper than the M5 version. You still get the same 16GB of RAM and 512GB of storage, and a chip that Apple will likely support for years to come. (The company still supports M1, which came out in 2020.) If you're set on the M5 MacBook Air, consider saving a bit by going through Apple's education store .

Samsung 16-inch Galaxy Book 5 Pro 360

If you need a large, thin and light laptop that runs Windows 11, this Copilot+ PC from Samsung might suit you. The 16-inch Galaxy Book 5 Pro 360 has an Intel Core 7 Ultra processor with 16GB of RAM and 1TB of storage—double that of the MacBook Air above. It also has a touchscreen 3K AMOLED display with a refresh rate of 120Hz. The integrated graphics won't get you far for gaming, but if you need a capable machine for school, work, or personal use, this is a great all-around machine.

HP EliteBook 6 G1i

Let's up the ante a bit. This HP EliteBook comes with a whopping 64GB of RAM. That's potentially overkill for most students and workers, but it does mean that this machine is a multitasker's dream. (You'll likely never run out of Chrome tabs.) It comes with an Intel Core Ultra 7 255U processor with a 1TB PCIe SSD for storage. The 16-inch IPS display is lower-res than the other laptops I've noted so far, as its only a 1200p panel. That's just a bit more pixels than you'd find in a 1080p display: Not bad, but not 3K or 4K. That

Want to Break an Ultrarunning Champion? Send Her to Bhutan.

TJ Pitre · Trail Runner Magazine

It was 5:30 A. M., pitch dark, 15 degrees Fahrenheit, and day three of the Snowman Race. We were camped in a village in the Lunana Valley in northern Bhutan, just a stone's throw below the Tibetan border in the heart of the Eastern Himalayas.

"How're we feeling?" I asked fellow runners in the dining tent over a breakfast of fried rice, eggs, pancakes, and sausage.

"Haha ha haaa!" roared Pascal Egli, an acclaimed Swiss mountain runner and glaciologist with tired bags under his mahogany eyes.

Privately, Pascal was worried about his injury-riddled knees. He wasn't sure he could finish the five-day race, and he was anxious about putting any staff in jeopardy. This wasn't just another trail race where you could drop out at the next aid station. The nearest road was a five-day walk away. The only escape option: a helicopter rescue about 6 miles into the day's 23-mile stage with 6,500 feet of climbing. He was considering it.

Buddhist monks chanting and praying for the land and safe passage of the runners at the start of the Snowman Race in Laya, Bhutan. (Photo: Meghan Hicks/Snowman Race)

"I think it will be very tough," said Leki, a Bhutanese runner and forager from Laya, the village where the race started. We were all nervous about Gophu La Pass, which topped out at 17,896 feet. "The trail will be rocky and with ice. I think today will be the most challenging," he nodded.

Bucking the trend, I was feeling optimistic about the day. The forecast was sunny and I believed—OK, I hoped—that today's stage wouldn't wreck me as badly as the first two, which I'd finished much slower than anyone anticipated. I thought maybe I was finally adjusting to the altitude and might be able to run today.

On the start line, the 16 of us racers laughed like giddy kids about to go to recess. "Also don't die!" Luke Nelson, a runner and physician's assistant from Pocatello, Idaho, yelled.

Little did I know I wouldn't smile like that for a long time.

At His Majesty's Invitation

The Snowman Race is a 110-mile, five-day stage race that follows a historic trekking route through the Bhutanese Himalayas. It's a vision of His Majesty, the ever-popular, 44-year-old king of Bhutan, Jigme Khesar Namgyel Wangchuck, who believes trail runners are the ideal witnesses to share the impacts of our warming planet—specifically Bhutan's melting glaciers—with the wider world.

I honestly didn't believe Luke when he told me His Majesty came up with this idea: a mountainous stage race doubling

as a climate change publicity stunt. I mean, let's be real, trail running is a niche sport, at best. Why us? Wouldn't it be easier to ask an NBA player to tweet something about melting glaciers?

"No. His Majesty specifically said trail runners are best suited to see the impacts," Luke said, adding something about how I'd be a moron to miss out on this invitation. Known for prioritizing "gross national happiness" over gross domestic product, Bhutan opened its borders to visitors in 1974. The country limits tourists in an effort to preserve a landscape that remains so untouched, you can only see the glaciers by trekking for days on foot. In addition to the seven Bhutanese runners, the government would sponsor the nine foreigners invited to the race this year, waving the \$150 per day tourist visas. We'd just pay for our flights and voluntary carbon offsets.

"Trail running is a niche sport, at best. Why us? Wouldn't it be easier to ask an NBA player to tweet something about melting glaciers?"

I received the invitation in August, and the race was slated for October. I chewed it over for a few days. I despise being cold. I'd never done a stage race before. I feared my year-long back injury flaring up. I'd need my advisor's permission to miss a month of school.

But, this was a climate change race! Since winning the Leadville 100 in 2016 and helping to start the trail running chapter of Protect Our Winters shortly after, I've spent my running career combining racing with environmental advocacy. Could a race halfway around the world actually serve as environmental advocacy?

Curious, honored, supported by my advisor, and just scared enough, I said yes.

‘Project Hail Mary’: Real Space Science, Real Astrophotography

EditorDavid · Slashdot

Project Hail Mary has now grossed \$300.8 million globally after earning another \$54.1 million this weekend from 86 markets, reports Variety, noting that after just nine days it's now Amazon MGM's highest-grossing film ever. And last weekend it had the best opening for a “non-franchise” movie in three years, adds the Associated Press — the best since 2023's *Oppenheimer*:

Project Hail Mary, which cost nearly \$200 million to produce... is on an enviable trajectory. Its second weekend hold was even better than that of *Oppenheimer*, which collected \$46.7 million in its follow-up frame.

But the movie is based on a book by The Martian author Andy Weir, described by one news outlet as “a former software engineer and self-proclaimed ‘lifelong space nerd’... known for his realistic and clear-eyed approach to scientifically technical stories.”

Project Hail Mary has plenty of real science in it, whether it be space mathematics, physics, or astrobiology... The film's namesake project is even comprised of the space programs of other nations, such as Roscosmos from Russia, the Chinese space program, and the European Space Agency...

The story relies on work NASA has done regarding exoplanets, or planets outside our solar system... [This includes a nearby star named Tau Ceti approximately 12 light years from Earth which is orbited by four planets — two once thought to be in “the habitable zone” where liquid water can exist.] Tau Ceti has long been the setting used by sci-fi authors and storytellers. Isaac Asimov used it for his Robot series. Arthur C. Clarke's “Rama” spacecraft came across a mysterious tetrahedron in the Tau Ceti system. Authors Ursula K. Le Guin and Kim Stanley Robinson also set stories in Tau Ceti, and it also serves as the extrasolar setting of the 1968 Jane Fonda film *Barbarella*. Most recently, the Bungie video game *Marathon* is set in the far-off system, serving as part of the background story for the extraction shooter, about a large-scale plan to colonize the Tau Ceti system.

The movie also mentions 40 Eridani A, according to the article, a real star about 16 light-years away that was said to be orbited by the fictional planet Vulcan, home to Star Trek's Mr. Spock. It's also mentioned in Frank Herbert's *Dune* as the star system of the planets Ix and Richese (“noted for their machine culture and miniaturisation,” according to the Stellar Australis site's “Project Dune” page).

And in a video on IMAX's YouTube channel, the film's directors explain how for a crucial scene they used non-visible-light photography, which is also an important part of modern astronomy. “Even the credits incorporate real astrophotography into the final moments,” the article points out, using the work of award-winning Australian astrophotographer Rod Prazeres. “The only difference between his work of capturing space data in images and what ended up

on the big screen was that he gave them ‘starless versions’ of his photographs to make it easier to place credit text over them.”

Prazeres wrote on his web site that he was touched the producers “wanted the real thing... In a world where CGI and AI are everywhere, it meant a lot...”

Read more of this story at Slashdot.

A Survival Guide to Ultrarunning Race Lottery Rejection

TJ Pitre · Trail Runner Magazine

It's like applying to college all over again. Whether you skip your long run to anxiously watch the results roll in, or you leave your phone at home and take out your jitters on the trails, the same fate awaits nearly us all. That dreaded email:

Thank you for your interest. We're sorry to inform you...

It's trail and ultrarunning race lottery season. Some of the big hitters, like Western States and Hardrock, drew the names of the precious few lucky enough to get into the 2025 race last weekend. Others, such as High Lonesome, Zegama, and Ultra-Trail du Mont-Blanc, are right around the corner. And then there are the ultra-exclusive Barkley Marathons of the world which even require you to write an admissions letter.

And like elite college admissions, your chances of getting in grow slimmer with each passing year. Sure, there are some races that come and go in popularity. (Do you remember Way Too Cool, Lake Sonoma, or Miwok? Nah, me neither.) But the staples remain as popular as ever. Well, actually, more popular. Race caps remain the same and entry numbers continue to climb as more runners turn to the trails.

Western States, for example, saw 9,993 applicants apply for a total of 260 lottery slots this year. Thanks to the weighted lottery system, first-year applicants had a whopping 0.4 percent chance of getting in. This ranks somewhere between getting stung to death by bees (0.0016 percent chance) and getting into Harvard (3 percent chance). Just a decade ago the total number of applicants was 2,704. Doing some back-of-the-napkin math, that means your chances of getting in now are roughly less than a third of what they were in 2014, never mind when Western States initiated a lottery in 2000 and just 583 weirdos bit.

While you fight back tears—your dream race, your top bucket list goal, your life's mission, eluded once again—acquaintances humble-brag about their lottery luck on Strava and Instagram:

"It's been my dream for five years to run the Hardrock 100, and this year I will be running it just three weeks after Western States and six weeks before UTMB!"

Five years? You think. Try five decades. (Never mind Hardrock was established in 1992, what does it matter when you'll never get in anyway?) You unfollow that acquaintance. Or worse, you leave a passive aggressive comment, "Congratulations! You are so brave!"

Maybe your schadenfreude is punishing you. Before you punish yourself even further, overdo it on craft stouts, or do something drastic like sign up for a Hyrox race (just to get into something), we've rounded up a few last-ditch methods of salvation.

Do you know what's more epic than Hardrock? Running the length of the Appalachian Trail faster than anyone has done before. This is an extreme example, obviously, but the point remains: there are plenty of options for self-punishment. (Photo: Courtesy Tara Dower)

1. Quit running

Let's face it, ultrarunning is a waste of time at best, a mortal hazard at worst. It's expensive: so many lightly-used, \$250 shoes creating a fire-hazard in your doorway because they rub your Achilles but you can't bear to part with the sunk cost; yucky energy gels you dutifully deep-throat on your long runs to "practice fueling;" and chiropractor appointments that you pay for out of pocket because the U. S. healthcare system unduly fails to recognize the importance of preventative medicine and self-care.

Ultrarunning is also needlessly extreme. You do not need to run 100 miles to be "healthy," to feel a "runner's high," or to "make friends." In fact, as physical therapist and 1993 marathon world champion Mark Plaatjes laughed in my face as I lay on the treatment table recently, you don't need to burn your disposable income on treatments for that calf strain when you just run "for fun." "You feel great when you run less!"

And ultrarunning is not fun. How many times have you puked your guts out, hobbled into the finish on a sore foot, or fallen asleep on the trail? That's what I thought. But... maybe that's precisely what makes it fun. Type II, maybe Type III, fun is all you know. Where some see the 120-degree heat of the Western States canyons as a wish to end up in the hospital, you see an opportunity to prove you are a badass. Whereas others view Hardrock as an old man's club, you see it as a chance to finally be in the inner circle that's eluded you since middle school. Where the self-assured think of UTMB as the overly crowded Disneyland of trail running, you see the Instagrammable European vacation of a lifetime.

And who are you without the purpose of a big, hairy, scary goal on the calendar? What will you do if you can't justify skipping a few stressful hours at family holiday time to get a few peaceful hours to yourself on the trails? How will you manage if your Instagram bio doesn't say "ultrarunner?" How will you distract yourself at work without the virtual fireworks from your coworkers on Slack after you walk it into the finish of your next race?

If the answer to all of those questions is, I will not survive, then keep reading.

2. Find a backup (or several)

Look, I get it, you only care about getting into Hardrock. Or Western States. Or whatever, they are all miserable in their own ways. But per point number one, you cannot live without a race on the calendar. And you didn't get into Hardrock/Western States in this year, so forget it, it's gone to find another owner. You have to find a new race to run. The Hardrock/Harvest

Apple Now Requires Device-Level Age Verification in the UK. Could the US Be Next?

Editor David · Slashdot

Apple unveiled new device-level age restrictions in the UK on Wednesday. “After downloading a new update, users will now have to confirm that they are 18 or older to access unrestricted features,” reports Gizmodo.

“Users will be able to confirm their age with a credit card or by scanning an ID.”

For those underage or who have not confirmed their age, Apple will turn on Web Content Filter and Communication Safety, which will not only restrict access to certain apps or websites, but will also monitor messages, shared photo albums, AirDrop, and FaceTime calls for nudity. Apple didn’t specify exactly which services and features are banned for under-18 users, but it will likely be in compliance with UK legislation...

The British government does not require Apple and other OS providers to institute device-level age checks, but it does restrict minor access to online pornography under the Online Safety Act, which passed in 2023. So far, that restriction has only been implemented at the website level, but UK officials have been worried about easy loopholes to evade the age restrictions, like VPNs.

The broader tech industry has been campaigning for some time to use device-level age checks instead in response to the rising tide of under-16 social media and internet bans around the world. Last month, in a landmark social media trial

in California, Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg also supported this idea, saying that conducting age verification “at the level of the phone is just a lot clearer than having every single app out there have to do this separately.” Pornhub-operator Aylo had advocated for device-level restrictions in the UK as well, and even sent out letters to Apple, Google, and Microsoft in November asking for OS-level age verification...

The most obvious question: Could this be brought state-side?

Read more of this story at Slashdot.

“Suck my toes, my darling” - Inkle’s book of essays by game writers reveals the secrets behind the worlds we play in

Robert Purchase · Eurogamer

Have you ever wondered what game writers think about games, or about how game writers think about games? When a story doesn’t click for you or when the writing jars, do you take a moment to wonder why? What is the thought behind this? What are the steps, the processes, the logic? Why are some things good and some things great? Is there a science behind it, and if there is, what is it? A new book published by Inkle - the celebrated British studio responsible for TR-49, Heaven’s Vault, 80 Days, A Highland Song, Expelled!, and plenty more - hopes to show us.

Read more

Apple didn't specify exactly which services and features are banned for under-18 users, but it will likely be in compliance with UK legislation.

EditorDavid

BRIEFS

IN BRIEF

Rafael Motamayor, /Film: A Knight of the Seven Kingdoms season 1 has made one of the best moments in Game of Thrones season 8 all the more powerful.

Vikki Blake, Eurogamer: Prolific former Valve writer, Chet Faliszek, has hit out at Epic Games founder Tim Sweeney, asking why anyone at Epic “should work hard” when staff have no agency and “the recent 1,000 job cuts didn’t come because of shareholder pressure”.

[Read more](#)

Vikki Blake, Eurogamer: Crimson Desert developer Pearl Abyss has deployed a new patch over the weekend across all platforms, adding five summonable mounts, decreasing loading times for fast travel and revival, and “more changes to controls as part of [the] ongoing efforts to improve the game’s controls”.

[Read more](#)

Connor Makar, Eurogamer: Pearl Abyss has addressed the future of Crimson Desert’s Intel Arc GPU support, after it was discovered the hardware wasn’t compatible at launch .

[Read more](#)

Victoria Phillips Kennedy, Eurogamer: As promised, the powers that be at Capcom have released an update for Resident Evil Requiem, which along with other fixes and such also adds the much-requested photo mode, so you can really capture all those nasties in their bloody glory (or, you could just take pics of Leon and Grace, your call).

[Read more](#)

Adam Davidson, How-To Geek: I’ve used a lot of smart home devices in my time, and I thought I’d seen them all. However, there’s one device I bought recently that’s been a real game-changer. It’s not something I ever thought I needed, but it’s had a big impact on my family and me.

Reece Bithrey, Eurogamer: The £229 / \$229 WiiM Sound Lite isn’t your conventional PC speaker, but one I think is a very clever addition to a desktop setup for use with movies, games and for general viewing. It might look like a conventional Wifi speaker, but underneath is one of the most feature-rich audio products I’ve tested at its modest price tag.

[Read more](#)

Sydney Butler, How-To Geek: I bet you never thought you’d still be buying spinning hard drives in the latter half of the ‘20s, but mechanical drives are still at the core of our mass storage. These devices are in your NAS, they’re in your home media server, and they’re plugged into your USB ports to store media and backups.

Sam Stone, /Film: A great miniseries knows how to tell an engaging story on television but also knows when to wrap it up rather than overstay its welcome, and these are the best.

Fran Ruiz, Eurogamer: One month and a half into its life cycle, Mewgenics is quite the indie sensation, and players have been wondering about the chances of it making the jump to other platforms, following its glowing launch on PC via Steam . Well, it seems you won’t have to wait for too long, as Edmund McMillen and his team are beginning to tease the first ports.

[Read more](#)

ZDNet, ZDNet: For Amazon’s Big Spring Sale, I’ve rounded up the best phone deals from major brands like Apple, Samsung, Motorola, and more. Sales are live now, so act fast.

Zack Zwiezen, Kotaku: The posts were part of his administration celebrating plans to bail farmers out of a situation created by Trump’s own actions

Robert Purchase, Eurogamer: Neil Newbon, the award-winning actor known for portraying the vampire Astarion in Baldur’s Gate 3 , has said he’s avoided roles recently because they wanted a repeat performance - or thereabouts - of the same thing.

[Read more](#)

Fran Ruiz, Eurogamer: Fortnite is one of the biggest games in the world, so it isn’t overly surprising to see Epic Games make adjustments to how the title is run as the game nears its tenth birthday. Maintaining a massive multiplatform operation filled with big IP collaborations isn’t cheap or easy, and that knowledge lead to some shocking news yesterday, 24th March, when over 1,000 positions were cut at the developer.

[Read more](#)

Matt Wales, Eurogamer: Lawyers for Subnautica 2 developer Unknown Worlds’ newly reinstated CEO Ted Gill are reportedly pushing for Krafton to be found in contempt of a recent court ruling after the publisher confirmed a May early access release for the highly anticipated underwater survival sequel without consulting Gill.

[Read more](#)

Matt Wales, Eurogamer: Happy birthday Game Boy Advance! It’s been 25 years since Nintendo’s handheld line-up bound into the world of proper 16-bit technicolour. Two and a half decades later, with a whopping 81.5m units sold, the diminutive machine is the stuff of legend. Its library is vast, home to many of video gaming’s most iconic characters, and it also managed to birth a whole bunch of series that would go on to become just as beloved themselves.

[Read more](#)

Wesley Hill, Eurogamer: Gears of War: Judgment’s Lyle Royce is a hell of a lot more than a hasty one-dimensional character in the very final boss fight.

[Read more](#)

Third one is kind of hard, because it's the heat of the day and it's the third one.

RUN | Powered by Outside

Atlantic Gazette

Vol. 1, No. 096 · 2026-03-30

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